

» FIFA WORLD CUP SPECIAL
DATA DRIVE

Kick-off at midnight, offers at zero

A glut of midnight kick-offs, **falling viewership** and weak ad returns have left FIFA World Cup 2026 without a broadcaster in India.

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The FIFA World Cup, nearly a century since its inception, has remained the crown jewel of international men's football.

Despite India never playing in the tournament, the spectacle has always taken centre stage among football fans. But 2026 carries a different writing on the wall.

The quadrennial carnival does not have a broadcaster. No TV channel, no streaming company has put its foot forward to take it up. Why is that so?

"Football viewership in India has

been on the decline for some time now. If you look at the Premier League, its valuation has fallen from \$145 million in 2013-14 to \$60 million in the latest deal," an industry expert tells *Sportstar*.

Sony Sports acquired the commercial rights for the FIFA World Cup 2014, 2018, and Euro 2016 for around \$90 million in 2013, which would be almost double the value today, adjusted for inflation.

Eight years later, Reliance picked up the 2022 World Cup rights for \$60 million.

FIFA had offered rights for the next two World Cups as a package to the Indian market for \$100 million last year. However, a lack of interest saw

the global football body reconsider the valuation to \$35 million.

Even then, interest did not emerge, exposing the broken economics of World Cup broadcasting in this part of the world.

"In India, the picture appears more nuanced than a simple lack of takers. Broadcasters are likely weighing a combination of structural and commercial considerations," says Rohit Potphode, Managing Partner - Sports, Gaming, eSports & Live Experiences, Dentsu India.

Dentsu is the commercial partner for the FIFA World Cup 2026 in Japan, which was also among the top viewers of the tournament in 2022.

"Japan is significantly different